

LESSON GUIDE

Shading & Texture

Shading technique translates your understanding of light into marks on paper. Texture describes the surface quality of objects — smooth, rough, matte, reflective. This lesson covers the mark-making vocabulary needed to render a wide range of surfaces convincingly.

4-WEEK PLAN

Week 1 — Smooth Gradients

Practice smooth value gradients from white to black using hatching, crosshatching, and blending. Aim for seamless transitions with no visible steps.

Week 2 — Stippling & Texture

Render a rough surface using only dots (stippling). Then render a smooth surface using only smooth gradients. Compare the effect of technique on perceived texture.

Week 3 — Material Studies

Draw three different materials: metal (reflective, high-contrast), cloth (soft, diffuse, with fold shadows), and wood (directional grain texture). Use appropriate mark-making for each.

Week 4 — Full Value Study

Complete a finished still life using the full value range from white to black. Apply appropriate surface texture to each object using the techniques studied this month.

KEY CONCEPTS

Smooth Gradients

Seamless value transitions created by hatching, blending, or digital brushwork. The technical foundation of realistic rendering.

Stippling

Rendering value through density of dots. Time-consuming but produces a distinctive textural quality. Used extensively in scientific and botanical illustration.

Rendering Techniques

Hatching, crosshatching, scumbling, blending, and burnishing — each technique produces different textures and value ranges.

Surface Texture

The visual quality of a surface as distinct from its value. Rough, smooth, matte, glossy, granular, fibrous — each requires different mark-making.

Value & Contrast Control

Controlling where your highest contrasts appear directs attention. The focal point gets the strongest contrast; edges and backgrounds get lower contrast.

Implied Texture

Suggesting texture through selective rendering rather than complete description. A few detailed marks in a key area imply texture across the whole surface.

ESSENTIAL RESOURCES

- Alphonso Dunn — Pen and ink drawing techniques (YouTube)
- Ctrl+Paint — Rendering and texture module (free online library)
- Proko — Shading with different pencil techniques (YouTube)
- Sinix Design — Texture and material rendering (YouTube)
- New Masters Academy — Still life rendering demonstrations